DREAMCATCHER

A science fiction story

Prologue

The sound of a burning hearth was the first thing Ludwig heard. It was humming quietly and sometimes making a loud cracking noise, as if the flames were sharp teeth biting through the logs, chewing them with vigor and satisfaction. It made Ludwig hungry, as he sat in an old leather armchair curled under a blanket.

It was a cold winter night in Norway, the winds howling outside the house walls, and Ludwig knew that a trip to the cold kitchen would drain all the warmth and happiness out of him. Thankfully, he did not have to make it, as he suddenly found he was already holding a tuna sandwich in his right hand. It is a very good feeling indeed, to recognize a hard problem and then watch it unravel all by itself. Sadly, though, Ludwig's time was nearly running out, and there was an alarm at the back of his mind ringing louder and ever louder. And he knew that he would soon wake up and leave the house and struggle against the frosty winds on his way to school. It was unfair, terribly unfair, that circumstances should have aligned so perfectly, only for Ludwig to be drawn out of this dream and into mundane reality, where nothing was ever perfect. Just before fading away, the remnants of Ludwig's consciousness were filled with anger and defiance, and he willed only for one thing—to keep the sandwich, the gift of this merciful world.

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But it was too late. Sharply Ludwig opened his eyes and sat up in his bed, all sleepiness drained out of him. The memories from the dream were still clear in his mind, but now they seemed fake and impossible. Ludwig's house had neither a hearth, nor any leather chairs. Feeling slightly disappointed, Ludwig reached out with his right hand to silence the alarm that kept ringing, but—oh wonder!—his hand was holding a tuna sandwich, just as luscious as he'd remembered it. He turned it over and saw that it was just a regular sandwich, yet somehow it felt both alien and familiar at the same time. Ludwig could have pondered the reasons and consequences of what had just happened, but instead he did what any prudent 9-year-old would do—he quickly ate the sandwich and started packing his bag for school.

Not long after, a similar event occurred, and this time it shook humanity to its very core. A young forensic analyst named Paul Mason finally got home at eleven p.m. after a hellish day at work. He had just moved to South Carolina, and he had just examined his first crime scene.

He went into this line of work because he had always been good at noticing details, and his life had always felt too ordinary, so he had decided to spice it up by connecting his career with crime. However, after seeing the site of a gruesome murder deep in the national forest, after methodically examining the layer of blood splashed over the bushes, after counting the poor girl's broken teeth and noticing her torn clothing and the bruising around her crotch, and the marks of dried tears around her dead eyes, he was starting to seriously doubt his career choices.

Paul could only console himself by thinking of the forest. He had seen its full glory from the helicopter on his way to the crime scene. An ocean of green, stretching into infinity, calm and immortal. What was this murder, but a tiny speck of crimson-red death in a vast, boundless sea of green growing life? As long as those mighty trees were standing tall and strong, he

thought, he could also find the strength to do this job. Because he had chosen it, and because someone had to do it.

Feeling broken but resolute, Paul lay down on his bed and closed his eyes, immediately falling into sleep.

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The next moment, he was back in the forest. He could not really understand why he had come back, because the body, the signs of struggle, the broken branches and stumped grass—everything was mysteriously gone, just like nothing had ever happened. *Where's the blood?* Paul thought, *did a rain wash it all away?*

As he walked around, he noticed the wind growing stronger and the daylight growing dimmer, the clouds above getting darker. Then the first drop of rain landed on his open palm, and it felt like a knife stabbing into his soul, because it was the crimson-red color of blood. Then another red droplet landed on his shoulder, then two more on his forearm, and a feeling of primal dread slowly crept into Paul. He could hear the trees croaking and shaking, as if trying to uproot themselves and run away, all to escape this rain which was Death itself. He could feel the rusty smell of blood as it started to pour from above.

Soon the whole sky was red, and Paul was red, and all around the green treetops and the bushes and the grass were all drinking this red poison and becoming the same shade of crimson-red. And Paul knew that they would never change back, that the horrible red drops had seeped and soaked into the trees and stained their very DNA. He knew that the green color of life would never be seen again.

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Paul woke up at nine a.m., his bedroom sheets drenched in sweat. They were soaking wet, but they were not red, and Paul let out a sigh of relief. It was all a dream. Then Paul thought about the previous day and the murder, and felt like shit again. *At least the sky ain't raining blood,* he thought with a thin smile.

Then he opened the window curtains to let in the morning sun, and his smile instantly disappeared, and his momentary relief turned to ash. The trees in the yard had leaves the color of blood, a familiar, but also somewhat alien shade of red.

Six hours before, while it was three a.m. in South Carolina, the time was eight a.m. in Berlin, twelve p.m in Astana, and four p.m. in Tokyo. All around the eastern hemisphere people looked up from their desks, stopped in the streets, left whatever they were doing to watch all the treetops, the decorative bushes, the lawns, and the house plants slowly turn crimson-red from top to bottom, as if someone were pouring viscous blood on top of them.

For a few minutes, no one could tear their eyes away from this foreign, yet painfully familiar color. They were like prey that stares in the deadly eyes of a predator, unable to look away and paralyzed by fear. They felt like they were looking into the eyes of Death.

Paul Mason came forward with a public apology the next day, but out of the few people who heard it, no one believed he was the cause of this worldwide tragedy. Paul himself died from exhaustion a week later. He could not allow himself to fall asleep, terrified of what his nightmares might do onto the world.

Since then it was not long before humanity woke up to this supernatural phenomenon, and realized that Paul had probably been telling the truth. Videos popped up on the Internet, showing people floating above their beds while asleep, or furniture changing shape and color, or objects appearing out of thin air. Soon there were official statements recognizing what came to be known as *reverse manifestation,* and governments around the world understood that this was an existential threat to humankind. If one man can alter the DNA of trillions of plants in his sleep, what stops someone from dreaming about killing someone they hate? What stops

them from dreaming a nuclear explosion? Of all people in the world, politicians are by far the most hated, and they know it better than anyone. So, when reverse manifestation made itself apparent, the powers of the world felt uniquely compelled to do something about it. It became a knife hanging above their heads.

Reverse manifestation was a new and mysterious phenomenon, but it would surely fall into the domain of science eventually, for it was an observable part of nature and not a figment of the mind. With no lack of funding and no lack of talent, in three mere months humanity developed a scientific framework around reverse manifestation. It was believed that an alternate universe existed, called the Dreamscape, that was different from our own, and that one could enter only in their sleep. To postulate the Dreamscape was necessary to prevent the violation of conservation laws: how else could an item simply appear out of nowhere, manifested by someone dreaming about it? Since neither energy nor mass can be created or destroyed, it had to have come from somewhere. Next came the questions of how humans can access the Dreamscape, and whether humans are the only ones that can do it, and what the laws of the Dreamscape are. Mammals had been known to show brain activity during sleep that was similar to having dreams, and numerous experiments were conducted to try and provoke reverse manifestation in non-human animals. These experiments made one thing clear: only humans can manifest dreams. This conclusion led the way to the idea that reverse manifestation is intimately connected with the defining feature of the human species—consciousness.

It was theorized that a person's consciousness is not made of matter, nor is it a mystical thing that cannot be defined. It is simply a *pattern* that the human brain exhibits through its activity, akin to a computer program running on hardware. The brain is the hardware, the mind is the program. This program keeps running even when the person is asleep, however it loses connection with the real world, becomes decoupled from it. In this state the program is replicated by the Dreamscape, through a mechanism yet unknown. The nature of the Dreamscape is such that events and thoughts are equivalent—to imagine something is the same as to manifest it. In other words, the Dreamscape is a world of patterns, a world of distortions that propagate through a simple medium. It is not unreasonable that the native patterns of the Dreamscape are also a form of consciousness, in which case it might be a sentient being who is interested in replicating other sentient beings' minds in itself, a program that simulates other programs. Which is to say, humanity was facing a potentially hostile extraterrestrial intelligence.

Once in the Dreamscape, a person's consciousness enters a world of experience entirely created by thought. The thought becomes reality in the Dreamscape, and through some unknown channel it can become reality in our own world, presumably since two instances of the same program share a link, similar to quantum entanglement between particles. This link came to be known as the *mind tunnel*. The sentient being of the Dreamscape may be able to utilize the mind tunnel to enact change in our own universe. Perhaps, the Dreamscape had discovered the human civilization only recently, which is why reverse manifestation had never been recorded in history.

A very fortunate discovery was the fact that the mind tunnel was typically very narrow, so most people were incapable of manifesting any large-scale events in their sleep. However, there were outliers—extraordinary individuals who could build whole cities in their sleep, who could make all cats in the world bark like dogs, or teleport mount Everest to the moon. If the mind tunnel of the average person were one meter in diameter, Paul Mason's mind tunnel would be as wide as the continent of Africa. It was a wild stroke of luck indeed, that Paul Mason's first manifestation was so harmless, and it was a hero's act to stay awake until his very death, for there is no saying what horrors might have come alive if Paul had allowed himself to enter the Dreamscape again.

As soon as scientists developed a method of measuring the width of a person's mind tunnel, people all over the world underwent mandatory testing. Of people like Paul Mason, there was

fewer than one thousand on the planet. These people were not to be envied, as they were hauled to special facilities for monitoring, and were forced to take experimental drugs that would prevent them from having dreams.

Yet even with the most dangerous people isolated, the threat still loomed over human society. During the first month after Mason's Red Rain, a prison guard fell asleep at his post and accidentally opened the electronic locks in half of the prison's cells, setting free hundreds of criminals. A couple of weeks later, someone fell asleep on an airplane and manifested a bird that flew into its turbine and caused the airplane to crash into the ocean. Only ten passengers survived.

Physicists, neurologists, and engineers all over the world worked late hours, preferring insomnia over the treacherous land of the Dreamscape. After four months since the Red Rain, they had engineered a device, about the size of a microwave oven, which could prevent people from having dreams in an area of about thirty meters. After another month, it was the size of a phone and could cover a radius of two hundred meters.

This device came to be known as the *dream inhibitor*. Within one week, one thousand inhibitors were produced worldwide. Another week later, it was one million. By the end of the third week, these devices were distributed to all major populated areas in the world. By the greatest feat of scientific engineering and social coordination, humanity erected a shield against the Dreamscape in less than half a year.

And once humanity was shielded, it would prepare its own attack.

Chapter 1

Susan woke up and thought she'd had the weirdest dream. She'd been camping near a quiet water stream in the forest, somewhere in the English countryside. Her school classmates had been there with her, which could not have been for real, since it was still summer break and her classmates were all far away, either in London or spending their summer on a family getaway, like she was. It was only a week until September 1st, though, so she would see them soon enough.

Anyway, this is not why Susan had found her dream especially weird. Leaving her classmates at camp, she had walked down to the stream to wash the greasy aluminium bowls they had used for lunch. All around her was the presence of nature. Below, a clear cold stream of water, like a stroke of brush, running over a floor of rounded pebbles. Above, a painting of rustling leaves on the blue canvas of the sky. All wrought in the colors of the Earth: grey, brown, blue, and green.

After standing in the water for what felt like hours, Susan had been meaning to head back to camp, when suddenly a wave of melancholy had struck her mind, and she'd felt contempt for the trees and grass and small animals around her, and that maybe they should just *die*. An inexplicable anger had risen in her, and for a split second she'd pictured all the forest around her consumed by fire, her classmates screaming in agony and writhing in the flames. Luckily, she had not remained in that burning world for more than a heartbeat, because a moment later she was back near the quiet stream and among the singing of the summer birds, with a woman's hand resting firmly on her shoulder. There had been a ring of silver on that hand, with a gemstone of emerald green. That emerald stone was the last thing Susan remembered before she woke up.

Today was the day Susan and her parents were returning to London. Her father Rory was driving carefully on the bumpy country road. He was not a strong man, Susan knew, but he had always been her favorite parent, because he'd rarely ever punished her for her misdeeds, and he'd always treated her with the understanding and respect that a child often desires. He had short black hair, a hairless chin, small ears and an awkward nose below a pair of grey eyes that radiated curiosity and intelligence.

Unlike her father, Susan's mother Iris had always been strict, although Susan was now old enough to understand that to be a loving parent is to be a strict one. Iris had a rich flow of curly brown hair about her sharp face, matching her hazel eyes which gazed with ferocity and intent from under her prominent brows. Susan was sure it must have taken all of Rory's bravery to approach his wife-to-be in college, beautiful but intense as she was.

Susan had her mother's hazel eyes, with less of Iris's intensity and more of Rory's innocent curiosity. Her brows were furrowed as she sat in the back seat of the car, as Susan was deep in thought. She was trying to analyze her dream, and it didn't make sense. She knew that dreams were mostly weird and devoid of logic, but they had to take source from the thoughts and emotions of the dreamer. At least, that had always been the case for Susan. She had dreamt once she was late for class, other times she'd dreamt she could talk to wild animals. But an entire forest seared by flame, her own friends burning alive? This was not something

she had thought about, or feared, and definitely not something she desired. The dream had left an aftertaste of something alien, something Susan could not explain.

At least one thing she could be certain of—the hand that lay upon her shoulder before she woke, and the silver ring thereon, surely belonged to Ms. Ackerley,